

Chapter 52-4

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Inside the rest room, it was very quiet. The air humidifier on the makeup table was still working, spraying fine mist.

Qi Taitai stood there with her arms crossed, carefully examining Liang Shi. "You've indeed grown up."

Liang Shi's tone was unfriendly: "If you have something to say, say it. If not, I'm leaving."

She was using coldness to disguise herself, acting half-真 and half-fake.

"Did you go find Qi Jiao?" Qi Taitai finally steered the conversation to the main topic. "What did you want with Qi Jiao? Was it to reminisce about old times?"

Liang Shi frowned: "Are you stalking Qi Jiao?"

"Do I need to stalk my own daughter?" Qi Taitai laughed lightly. "Qi Jiao is very obedient. She never hides anything from me."

"Oh." Liang Shi stopped being evasive. "I did go find Qi Jiao, and Qi Jiao should have told you what I went there for. I went to find her to look for a child from her class. It was just coincidental that she happened to be that class's teacher."

Qi Taitai looked at her, her tone slightly rising: "Is that so?"

Liang Shi: "Believe it or not."

Qi Taitai tucked a strand of fallen hair behind her ear, her movements full of charm.

But no one was there to appreciate it.

Her voice became deeper: "Little friend, you're really not obedient now."

"So what?" Liang Shi looked at her, her eyes containing fierceness. "What do you want to do? Lock me in a little dark room? Have your daughter force me to speak? Or use a rattan cane to whip me? Qi Taitai, I've grown up."

For a moment, Qi Taitai was also frightened by her gaze.

But she quickly readjusted: "No wonder your mother says you're smart—you still remember things that happened when you were so small. Our Jiao Jiao has probably forgotten by now."

"It has nothing to do with me." Liang Shi became even more distant. The strong walls she had built with her forceful attitude became even more solid. "If you called me here just to say this nonsense, then I won't keep you company."

"Little friend, you're still the same as when you were little." Qi Taitai laughed lightly. "So impatient. Can't you listen to what adults have to say?"

"Sorry." Liang Shi said: "I'm the adult now."

Qi Taitai's expression changed slightly.

Liang Shi continued: "You're no longer an adult. Twenty years have passed—you're already an old person now. Don't try to threaten me in that way anymore. If I ever find audio or video evidence someday, I'll send you to prison. Child abuse—even if it's been over twenty years, even if the law doesn't prosecute, I'll still make you lose all reputation."

"So where's your audio and video evidence?" Qi Taitai sneered. "Liang Shi, you're getting more and more naive."

"What if someday Heaven sees you've done too much evil and just delivers that evidence right to me?" Liang Shi said: "This world has karmic retribution¹. Do you believe it?"

After hearing this, Qi Taitai's eyes flashed with uncontrollable malice. She frowned and asked viciously: "Then why haven't the evildoers died yet?"

"They will eventually." Liang Shi said: "People act, Heaven watches²."

Qi Taitai laughed coldly: "Naive."

But a moment later, she returned to her previous demeanor.

She looked at Liang Shi with a nostalgic expression: "You look really good now, and you believe in justice and righteousness, and you've married a wife. By the way, is your wife pregnant?"

Liang Shi frowned: "What does it have to do with you?"

Qi Taitai said: "Just asking casually."

She stared intently at Liang Shi, as if looking at someone else through her. Her tone was full of nostalgia and attachment: "If my Jiao Jiao could see how you look now, she'd probably be very happy."

Liang Shi: "..."

Didn't Qi Jiao already see her?

She didn't understand what Qi Taitai meant.

Obviously, Qi Taitai didn't intend for her to understand—she was just venting her own emotions.

After venting, Qi Taitai became cold again: "Liang Shi, I don't care what you want to do, but don't bother Qi Jiao anymore. What my daughter wants to do is naturally not for you to manage."

She said word by word: "Mind your own business."

Liang Shi looked at her like this, seeming to find her vulnerable point.

Even someone as strong as her was just pretending.

So Liang Shi overcame the fear in her heart and confronted her forcefully: "What if I refuse?"

Qi Taitai closed her eyes. When she opened them again, a sharp light flashed through: "If you make me lose this daughter again, I will kill you."

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Qi Taitai was like a gust of wind—she came quickly and left quickly too.

After she left, Liang Shi went to eat with Zhao Ying.

Originally they were supposed to meet Zhao Xuning, but Zhao Xuning was swamped at the hospital and couldn't come.

Zhao Ying didn't ask about what happened between her and Qi Taitai, but provided some information instead.

While they were talking in the rest room, Zhao Ying had called her dear mother and managed to extract some information about Qi Taitai.

Qi Taitai's name was Yang Jiani. She had originally been among Haizhou's wealthy elite, but when the Yang family got involved in a bribery case, they were directly investigated and fell from grace. Yang Jiani then married her high school classmate Qi Xiangui, who was now CEO Qi of Qida Company, becoming Qi Taitai.

While Qi Xiangui always maintained the public image of doting on his wife and daughter, he wasn't good to his family.

Qi Xiangui had a problem—he loved drinking, and when he drank too much, he would throw things.

Zhao Ying's mother had previously played mahjong at the Qi house and had seen Qi Xiangui drunk. He would ramble on endlessly, and later even flipped their mahjong table.

Yang Jiani had originally studied opera. She had loved it since childhood, but after marrying Qi Xiangui, he didn't like her showing her face in public, so she gave up her career.

However, she always wore qipaos, regardless of the occasion.

She wore qipaos with exceptional grace too.

Over time, people would actually avoid her, not wanting to clash with her style.

"What about her attitude toward her daughter?" Liang Shi asked.

Zhao Ying said: "She's especially good to her daughter. My mother said compared to her, I'm like I was picked up from somewhere."

According to Zhao Yulin, Yang Jiani's most beloved was her daughter. She would give her whatever she wanted, even kneeling down to wipe her daughter's shoes and put them on for her, loving her to the bone.

Hearing this, Liang Shi frowned.

She kept thinking about Yang Jiani's final words, always feeling there was something suspicious about them.

That evening when she saw Xu Qingzhu, the two discussed it. Xu Qingzhu frowned and said: "Repeat what she said again."

Liang Shi relied on her good memory to repeat: "If you make me lose this daughter again, I will kill you."

Xu Qingzhu's eyes widened, and she and Liang Shi said simultaneously: "Again?"

—Yes, again.

As everyone knew, Qi Xiangui and Yang Jiani had only ever had one daughter from beginning to end, and that was Qi Jiao.

But Qi Jiao was still alive.

So who was the daughter who had died?

Footnotes: ¹ Karmic retribution: The Buddhist/Taoist concept that good and evil deeds will eventually be repaid in kind ² People act, Heaven watches: A Chinese idiom meaning that even if people think no one sees their actions, Heaven (or cosmic justice) is always watching